

Scandinavians and verb-second in Northumbrian Old English

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<http://walkden.space/gersum.pdf>

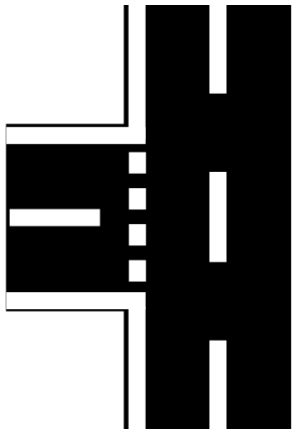
Introduction

In this talk I aim to:

- ▶ Characterize (as far is possible) the nature of clausal word order in Northumbrian Old English (OE)
- ▶ Explain how it got like that, critically evaluating existing proposals
- ▶ In particular, assess the role of contact with Norse in shaping Northumbrian Old English syntax

Structure

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The contact scenario
Summary and conclusion
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Languages and definitions

- ▶ **Norse**: any and all varieties of North Germanic that came into contact with Old and Middle English, following e.g. Thomason & Kaufman (1988); Townend (2002); Lutz (2012, 2013); Pons-Sanz (2013); = 'Scandinavian' of other authors
- ▶ **Northumbrian Old English**: the variety of Old English attested in the following texts:
 - ▶ Early (pre-10th-century): *Cædmon's Hymn*, *Bede's Death Song*, *Leiden Riddle*, Ruthwell Monument inscription (later?), Franks Casket inscription, names
 - ▶ Late (10th century): *Lindisfarne Gospels* glossal translation, Owun's portion of the *Rushworth Gospels* glossal translation (Rushworth 2), the *Durham Ritual*
- ▶ Important not to assume at the outset that Northumbrian OE texts all behave the same (Fernández Cuesta & Senra Silva, 2008)

Strict verb-second

Strict verb-second (V2): exactly one constituent must precede the finite verb.

- (1) kamb : koþan : kiari : þorfastr
comb good made Thorfastr
'Thorfastr made (this) good comb.'
(Norse, E 4, Lincoln, ?11th century; Jesch, this conference)
 - (2) Lauerd, of me haue I noht, bot þu sende it me.
lord of me have I nothing but you send it me
'Lord, by myself I have nothing unless you send it to me.'
(Middle English, *Northern Prose Rule of St. Benet*, 15th century;
CMBENRUL,3.60 in PPCME2, Kroch & Taylor, 2000)
- ▶ Found in most Germanic languages; rare elsewhere (Holmberg, 2015)
 - ▶ Focus today is on declarative main clauses: interrogatives and subordinate clauses not considered

In West Saxon OE and southern Middle English, V2 is not always found:

- ▶ V2 when subject is discourse-new
- ▶ **V3** (normally) when subject is discourse-old, as in (3)
- ▶ **V3** virtually exceptionless when subject is pronominal, as in (4)

(see van Kemenade & Westergaard, 2012; Eitler & Westergaard, 2014; Walkden, 2014, 2015, 2017 among many others)

- (3) þeah hweðer *his hired* *men* ferdon ut
 though whether his household men went out
 ‘Nevertheless his retainers went out.’ (cochronE,
 ChronE_[Plummer]:1087.26.2994 in YCOE, Taylor et al. (2003))
- (4) æfter his gebede *he* ahof þæt cild up
 after his prayer he lifted the child up
 ‘After his prayer he lifted the child up.’
 (cocathom2,+ACHom_II,_2:14.70.320)

Context for this talk

Kroch & Taylor (1997) and Kroch et al. (2000) (henceforth KTR):

- ▶ Two different varieties of Middle English:
 - ▶ Northern Middle English ('strict V2')
 - ▶ Southern Middle English
(what I will call 'V3', as in West Saxon Old English)
- ▶ Northern speakers accommodating to Southern norms and hypercorrecting leads to loss of V2 entirely in favour of Modern English SVO (eventually)

Strict V2 in the North

- ▶ Side question for KTR: how did strict V2 in Northern Middle English arise?
 - ▶ KTR claim 1: strict V2 is also found in Northumbrian OE.
 - ▶ KTR claim 2: *it was the result of contact with Norse* (cf. Miller, 2012, 144).
- ▶ These are the key claims I will be investigating in this talk.
- ▶ I won't address the issue of the *loss* of V2, which is the main point of KTR. I assume their story to be basically correct.

Old Northumbrian word order

Early Northumbrian OE texts

All verse; nothing conclusive (as KTR also observe).

- ▶ Franks Casket inscription, Bede's Death Song, Leiden Riddle, and Cædmon's Hymn contain no relevant examples.
- ▶ First line of Cædmon's Hymn *nu scylun hergan* 'now should praise' has no subject, see van Gelderen (2000, 126).



Ruthwell Monument

Ruthwell Monument inscription, only possible relevant declarative clause:

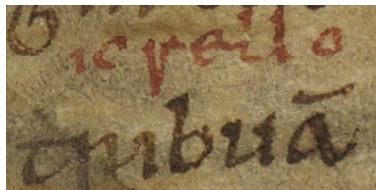
- (5) *mip strelum giwundad alegdun hiaē*
 with arrow.DAT wounded lay they
 hinæ limwoerignæ
 him.ACC limb-weary
 ‘Wounded with arrows they lay him down,
 weary’

- ▶ Runes may be as late as early 11th century (Conner, 2008).
- ▶ PP could also be read as part of a different clause (as supported by parallel section in *Dream of the Rood*).



Syntax of glossal translations

- ▶ Nagucka (1997): the term 'gloss' is misleading for Lindisfarne, as it shows sensitivity to clausal syntactic properties rather than being word-for word
- ▶ Nagucka's suggested term: 'glossal translation'.
- ▶ KTR's study is based on lexical insufficiency in Lindisfarne and Rushworth 2.
- ▶ Crucial information comes from two sources:
 - ▶ Unprompted *deviations* from the Latin original
 - ▶ *Lexical insufficiency*: one word in Latin translated by more than one in Old English
 - ▶ e.g. *ic sello* 'I give' for Latin *tribuam* in Durham Ritual – note word order!



KTR on Lindisfarne and Rushworth 2

- ▶ Latin only very rarely uses the subject pronoun; glossator(s) have to insert a pronoun with the finite verb
- ▶ Most of the time the pronoun precedes the verb
- ▶ With a non-subject constituent initially, though, inversion (V2) is sometimes found (13.6%; figures based on Skeat's edition):

Dialect	Inversion	Total	Inversion (North. only)	Total
Northumbrian	5	58	14	82
West Saxon	0	58	–	–

Latin: oculos habentes

Lindisfarne: ego habbað gie

Rushworth: ego habbas ge
eyes have you

(Mark 8:18; *West Saxon:* eagan ge habbað)

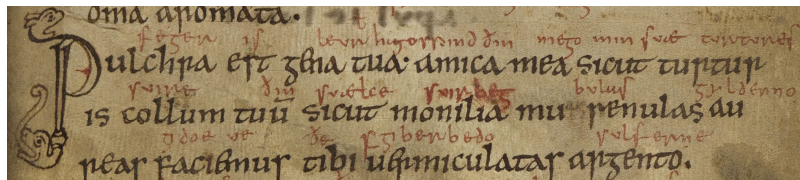
New evidence from the Durham Ritual

Durham Cathedral Library MS A.IV.19 – [digitized in 2016](#) as part of the Durham Priory Library Recreated project (CC-BY-NC-ND 4.0)

Data: Stevenson (1840) edition, checked against manuscript

<i>Latin:</i>	murenulas	aureas	faciemus	tibi
<i>North. OE:</i>	bvlas	gyldenno	gidoe ve	ðe
	necklaces	golden	make we	you.obl

“we make golden necklaces for you”



Durham Ritual: quantitative data

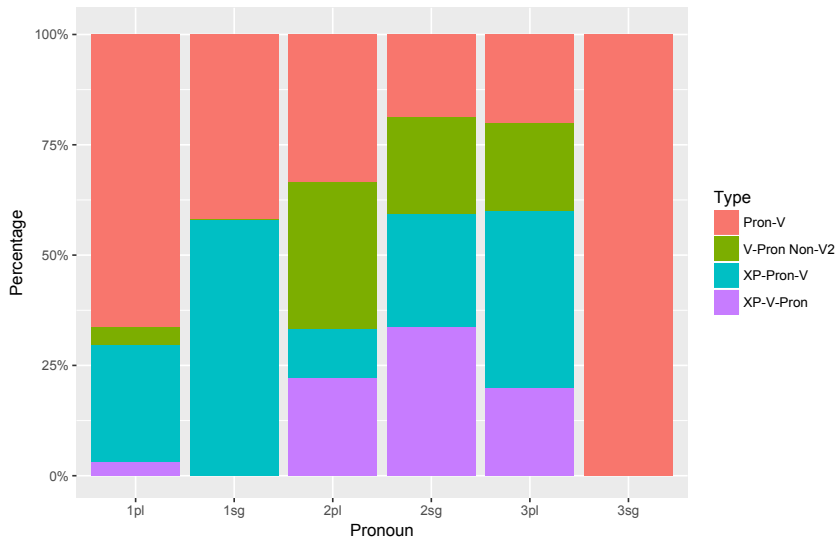
Declarative, non-conjoined main clauses only.

Pronoun	Pron-V	V-Pron non-V2	XP-Pron-V	XP-V-Pron	Total
<i>ic</i> (1sg)	23	0	32	0	55
<i>ðv</i> (2sg)	11	13	15	20	59
<i>he</i> (3sg)	1	0	0	0	1
<i>ve</i> (1pl)	216	13	87	10	326
<i>gie</i> (2pl)	3	3	1	2	9
<i>hia</i> (3pl)	1	1	2	1	5
Total	255	30	137	33	455

Proportion of inversion (V2) with an initial XP: 19.4%.

- ▶ Roughly consistent with what KTR find for Lindisfarne (13.6%)
- ▶ Written later, but more conservative? (Ross, 1970)
- ▶ Asymmetries between pronouns interesting!

Verb position, by pronoun



Summary: V2 in Northumbrian Old English

- ▶ Early texts: no evidence.
- ▶ Lindisfarne Gospels (KTR): 13.6%
- ▶ Durham Ritual (new study): 19.4%

It seems as if both V3 and V2 with inversion were native possibilities in Northumbrian Old English, but an important question is the extent of influence from the West Saxon standard.

The contact scenario

Theory of language contact

van Coetsem (1988, 2000); Smits (1998); Winford (2003, 2005):
psycholinguistically-driven model of transfer types.

Borrowing

- ▶ recipient-language agentivity
- ▶ conscious
- ▶ tends to affect (non-basic) lexical items most

Imposition

- ▶ source-language agentivity
- ▶ subconscious
- ▶ tends to affect stable domains (e.g. phonology, syntax) most
- ▶ Cf. Thomason & Kaufman's (1988) and Thomason's (2001) similar notion of 'shift-induced interference'.

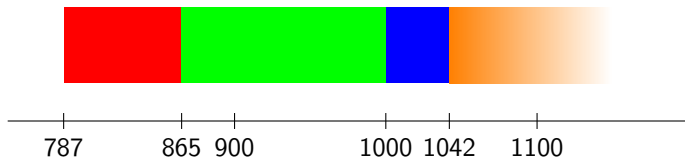
This model is adopted by many of the serious researchers in Norse-English contact, e.g. Townend (2002) and Pons-Sanz (2013).

Another possibility: **simplification** (Trudgill, 2011) caused by widespread L2 acquisition that is brief and intense at the population level.

Periods of Norse influence

Pons-Sanz (2013, 6–9): three ‘phases’ of Norse contact in OE.

- ▶ Phase 1: **hit-and-run** phase (end of 8th century to mid-9th century). Not much language contact.
- ▶ Phase 2: **settlement** phase (mid-9th century to 1000).
- ▶ Phase 3: **conquest** phase (1000 to 1042).
- ▶ (Phase 4: **shift** phase, 1042 to language death, area-dependent.)



Prestige and types of Norse influence

- ▶ Change in prestige relations.
 - ▶ Norse goes from superstrate to adstrate around the 10th century (Hock, 1986, 410; Townend, 2002, 204; Trudgill, 2011, 53; Pons-Sanz, 2013, 275.
 - ▶ (For a dissenting view see Lutz, 2012, 2013.)
- ▶ Shift phase may be most important outside the lexicon.
 - ▶ We expect *imposition* in the Norse-settled areas (see Townend, 2002 and Walkden & Morrison, 2017 for discussion).
 - ▶ Hence: grammatical influence and (more) basic vocabulary.
 - ▶ Also: *simplification*.
- ▶ But what about Northumbrian OE?

Which type of change is the rise of strict V2?

Which type of change is the rise of strict V2?

- ▶ Very unlikely to be *borrowing*.
 - ▶ Syntactic borrowing is questionable in general (Winford, 2005)
 - ▶ In Thomason's (2001, 70–71) terms, we are dealing with the “slightly more intense” type during the OE period, with few function words and “no introduction of features that would alter the types of structures found in the borrowing language”, other than (by hypothesis, potentially) V2.
- ▶ Could it be *imposition*? How does this square with the presence of V2 in (later) Old Northumbrian texts?
- ▶ Could it be due to morphological simplification?

Scenarios for the rise of strict V2

Three possibilities:

1. **Imposition:** Strict V2 was transferred directly into Old Northumbrian from Norse by L2 learners.
2. **Simplification:** Strict V2 is a result of the simplification of verbal morphology by L2 learners (KTR).
3. **There was no rise:** Old Northumbrian inherited strict V2 from Proto-West Germanic.

KTR's scenario:

- ▶ Norse-speaking L2 learners of English failed to learn Old English morphology
- ▶ Old English-style 'V3' word order is universally incompatible with later English morphology ('Rich Agreement Hypothesis')
- ▶ Word order therefore shifted to strict V2

Problems

- ▶ Problem for KTR: the Rich Agreement Hypothesis in general has fallen into disfavour (Bobaljik, 2002; Heycock & Wallenberg, 2013)
- ▶ Problem for any scenario involving L2 learners: Norse and OE were in all likelihood *mutually intelligible* (Townend, 2002; Rowe, this conference) – so why would there be extensive L2 learning in the 10th century?

The glossators

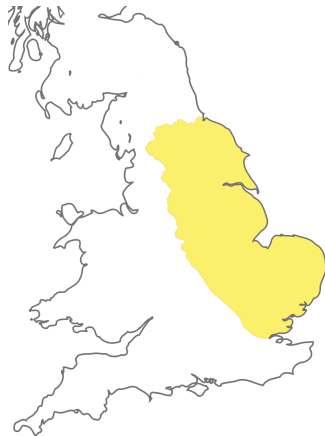
- ▶ Pons-Sanz (2013, 253–257): Aldred, the glossator of Lindisfarne (and likely of Durham Ritual), is from near Chester-le-Street, his workplace.
- ▶ Lexical evidence suggests he is “from an area with some, albeit not very heavy, Scandinavian presence” – only lexical borrowings, but not all from technical fields, e.g. *dearf* ‘bold’, *song*.
- ▶ Norse speakers present in small numbers, with weak ties

The status of Northumbria

Kroch & Taylor (1997, section 8):
Northumbria was “the area of contact at the appropriate time” (10th century). BUT:

- ▶ Northumbria north of the Tees, including Chester-le-Street, was outside the ‘Danelaw’ (see Holman, 2001)
- ▶ Little evidence for Scandinavian material culture in this area (Kershaw, this conference)
- ▶ Relatively few Norse place names are found in this area (Sawyer, 1971, 161)

Overall, area around Chester-le-Street was precisely NOT where heavy 9th-century Norse settlement is proposed (cf. Pons-Sanz, 2000, 15–39).



Approximate extent of the Danelaw circa 1100, based on Holman (2001, 4–7)

Place names

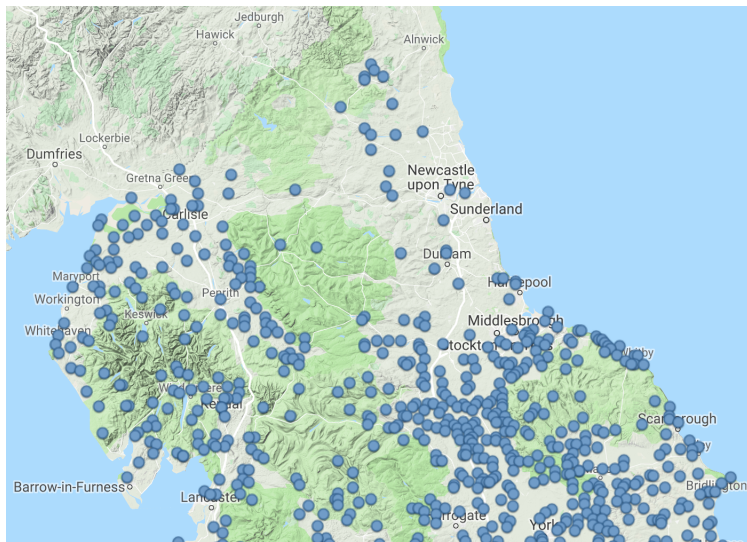


Figure: Screenshot from [British Museum 2014 exhibition website](#)

Evidence from function words

Pons-Sanz (2013): only a handful of function words from Norse found in OE (compared to 174 open-class lexical words).

- ▶ Conjunction *oc*: handful of examples; only convincing one is Arras scribble, difficult to date
- ▶ Prepositions *fra*, *fro* and *fraward* and conjunction *baðe*: no examples before eleventh century
- ▶ Pronoun *hanum*: found only once, in Aldbrough (Yorkshire) inscription, eleventh century
- ▶ None of these items occurs in a Northumbrian text
- ▶ None of these items is indisputably Norse (Pons-Sanz, 2013, 127)

Conclusion: only lexical borrowings in Old Northumbrian (see also Thomason & Kaufman, 1988, §9.8.6.10).

- ▶ Preposition *til*, used in Old Northumbrian, is likely to be a West Germanic retention
- ▶ Conjunction *æd* or *æt* is likely to be a reduced OE by-form (Pons-Sanz, 2013, 415)

Interim summary of contact situation

No clear support from external factors, place-name evidence, or lexical evidence for either an imposition or a simplification scenario.

Summary and conclusion

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Late Northumbrian OE texts show evidence for strict V2, but Norse is almost certainly not to blame:

- ▶ KTR's rich-agreement-based scenario is suspect on theoretical and empirical grounds
- ▶ Direct imposition of V2 by acquirers also highly unlikely: little evidence of imposition before the 11th century, and no reason to expect it
- ▶ Northumbria in particular would not be the place to look for intensive Norse influence (cf. Thomason & Kaufman, 1988, 286–287: Norsified English spread from Lindsey in the East Midlands)

Could strict V2 actually be an inheritance from Proto-Northwest Germanic? (cf. Walkden, 2017, *contra* Walkden, 2014) Evidence from early runic inscriptions is often taken to militate against this conclusion, but there is V2 here (Eythórsson, 2011).

Thanks

Thank you for listening!

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